In the oceans, the most acutely destructive pollution has resulted from disasters involving oil tankers and oil terminals. When the *Exxon Valdez* supertanker broke up on rocks off the coast of Alaska in 1989, 11 million gallons (50 million liters) of crude oil were released into the North Pacific. The oil smothered or poisoned an estimated 250,000 seabirds, 250 Bald Eagles, 2,800 sea otters, 300 harbor seals, and 22 killer whales. Billions of salmon and herring eggs also died. Further catastrophic damage followed in 1991, during the Iraq War, when Iraqi forces opened the valves of an offshore oil terminal and released at least 380 million gallons (1,700 million liters) into the Persian Gulf. The long-term effects of such disasters are still unfolding and have yet to be fully understood.

Much of our nondegradable products ends up in the oceans. Since the 1950s, around 8.3 billion tons of plastic has been produced, of which only a fifth has been recycled or incinerated. Each year, around 1.5 million tons of plastic reaches the oceans, and is responsible for the deaths of huge numbers of marine animals.



Orcas may become extinct as a result of PCB (polychlorinated biphenyl) pollutants. The compound becomes more concentrated higher in the food chain, and orcas are apex predators.